颜色的意思

白色的花和红色的花

What Colours Mean

White flowers and red flowers

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names and words above HSK 2 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 苏菲[†]是法国[‡]人，在北京学中文，已经学了一年了。她的中国朋友王丽[§]请她春节去家里过年。因为这是苏菲第一次在中国过年，所以她很高兴，想给王丽的家人买一个好礼物。

白色的礼物

2 星期六，苏菲去商店买东西。她看了半天，最后买了一些白色的花，还买了一件白色的衣服，是给王丽的奶奶的。她想："白色多好看啊！不但很干净，而且很漂亮。"

3 回到学校，她高兴地拿给王丽看。王丽看了，有点儿不好意思地说："苏菲，这些东西都很漂亮，可是春节的时候，最好别送白色的东西。""为什么？"苏菲不明白，"白色不好吗？"

† 苏菲 *Sūfēi* Sophie (a French student)
‡ 法国 *Fǎguó* France
§ 王丽 *Wáng Lì* Wang Li (Sophie's friend)

Sophie is French. She is learning Chinese in Beijing and has been studying it for a year now. Her Chinese friend Wang Li invited her home to celebrate the Spring Festival. Because it was Sophie's first New Year in China, she was very happy, and she wanted to buy a good present for Wang Li's family. 1

A White Present

On Saturday, Sophie went shopping. She looked for a long time and in the end bought some white flowers, and a white jacket as well, for Wang Li's grandmother. She thought, "White is so lovely! It's clean, and it's beautiful too." 2

Back at the university, she happily showed them to Wang Li. Wang Li looked and said, a little awkwardly, "Sophie, these things are all lovely, but at the Spring Festival it's best not to give white things." "Why?" Sophie didn't understand. "Is white bad?" 3

3 王丽†说：“在中国，白色和红色的意思很不一样。我给你讲讲吧。”

红色

4 王丽说：“中国人最喜欢红色。因为红色是快乐的颜色，所以过年的时候，到处都是红色。”“门上有红纸，红纸上写着大字；晚上有红色的灯；老人和孩子都穿红色的新衣服。”“家里有大喜的日子，大家也都穿红的、用红的。”

5 苏菲‡问：“那白色呢？”王丽说：“以前，家里有老人走了，人们就穿白色的衣服。”“因为白色是难过的颜色，所以过年的时候，大家都不送白色的东西。特别是白色的花，老人看见了会不高兴的。”“在中国，过年的时候，红色比白色好多了。”苏菲说：“原来是这样！还好我先拿给你看了。”

† 王丽 *Wáng Lì* Wang Li (Sophie's friend)　‡ 苏菲 *Sūfēi* Sophie (a French student)

Wang Li said, "In China, white and red mean very different things. Let me tell you about them." 3

Red

Wang Li said, "Chinese people love red most of all. Because red is the colour of happiness, at New Year there is red everywhere." "There's red paper on the doors with big characters written on it, there are red lights in the evening, and old people and children all wear new red clothes." "When a family has a wedding, everyone wears red and uses red things too." 4

Sophie asked, "And white?" Wang Li said, "In the past, when an old person in the family passed away, people wore white." "Because white is the colour of sadness, nobody gives white things at New Year. White flowers especially: old people would be upset to see them." "In China, at New Year, red is far better than white." Sophie said, "So that's how it is! Good thing I showed you first." 5

别的颜色

6 苏菲[†]又问：“黄色呢？黄色有什么意思？”王丽[‡]说：“很早以前，黄色是一个人的颜色。国家最大的那个人可以穿黄色的衣服，别的人都不能穿。”“现在黄色不但没有这个意思了，而且谁都可以穿。”

7 “那绿色呢？”“现在中国人说‘绿色’，常常是说健康。‘绿色的菜’，意思是很健康、很干净的菜。”苏菲笑了：“颜色的意思真多！中国的颜色不但好看，而且都有自己的意思。”

一样和不一样

8 苏菲想了想，说：“你知道吗？在法国[§]，白色是一个很好的颜色。”

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§ 法国 *Fǎguó* France

Other Colours

Sophie asked again, "What about yellow? What does yellow mean?" Wang Li said, "Long, long ago, yellow belonged to one person. The most important man in the country could wear yellow clothes, and nobody else could." "Now yellow doesn't mean that any more, and anyone can wear it." 6

"And green?" "Nowadays when Chinese people say 'green', they often mean healthy. 'Green vegetables' means very healthy, clean food." Sophie laughed. "Colours have so many meanings! Chinese colours aren't just pretty; each one has its own meaning." 7

The Same and Different

Sophie thought for a moment and said, "You know what? In France, white is a very good colour." 8

8 “女孩子大喜的日子，是她和男朋友要有自己的新家的那一天，她要穿白色的长衣服。”王丽[†]说：“真的吗？跟我们很不一样啊！”

9 王丽想了想，又说：“不过，现在也有一点儿一样了。很多中国年轻人在大喜的日子，也穿白色的长衣服。”“我姐姐去年也是这样：她早上穿白色的，晚上穿红色的。”苏菲[‡]说：“所以颜色的意思也会变！”王丽说：“对。以前和现在不一样，中国和法国[§]也不一样。可是有一点是一样的：送礼物的人，都想让别人高兴。”

10 春节那天，苏菲送给王丽的奶奶一些红色的花。奶奶很高兴，问她：“你怎么知道我喜欢红色？”苏菲笑着说：“因为我有一个很好的中文老师。”王丽也笑了。奶奶说：“你的中文说得比很多中国孩子还好！”那件白色的衣服呢？苏菲留给了自己。

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"On a girl's wedding day, the day she and her boyfriend start a home of their own, she wears a long white dress." Wang Li said, "Really? That's so different from us!" 8

Wang Li thought for a moment and said, "But now there's a bit that's the same. Lots of young Chinese people wear a long white dress on their wedding day too." "That's what my sister did last year: she wore white in the morning and red in the evening." Sophie said, "So the meanings of colours can change too!" "Right," said Wang Li. "The past and the present are different, and China and France are different too. But one thing is the same: people who give presents all want to make others happy." 9

On the day of the Spring Festival, Sophie gave Wang Li's grandmother some red flowers. Grandma was delighted and asked her, "How did you know I like red?" Sophie smiled. "Because I have a very good Chinese teacher." Wang Li laughed too. Grandma said, "You speak Chinese better than lots of Chinese children!" And the white jacket? Sophie kept it for herself. 10